

that contract, in much the same way that we grew into the partnership we have today.

You'll notice the title of this chapter is "choosing a mate," not "choosing a soulmate." It's remarkably pervasive, this idea of a soulmate; sappy love songs and romantic films are sure to keep it in perpetuity. But soulmates aren't discovered, they're grown. You start from nothing and work hard to establish your family dynasty, and the two of you are united against all the challenges you face in your marriage and your life. Overcoming obstacles and accomplishing your goals together—that's the brick and mortar of real partnership, and the key to financial stability and success.

FOUR RED FLAGS TO WATCH OUT FOR IN A MATE

If your Relationship Due Diligence checklist revealed some unsavory truths, it may be time to take your due diligence to the next level. Be especially wary of the red flags that follow.

1. **Long-term liabilities.** Here's a cold hard truth most people prefer to ignore: in most marriages, you're not just marrying your spouse, you are marrying his or her family and everyone in it. Nobody wants to talk about it, but if your partner's parents are broke and need financial help, it's going to be your problem. Who ends up taking care of the elderly when they don't have the money to take care of themselves? Their kids, and sometimes the extended family. If your potential in-laws are on a one-way street to financial destitution, chances are good your potential wife or husband will eventually be asked to start writing checks. Your due diligence can't stop with your partner; you've also got to take a cold hard look at your partner's *family's* ability to support themselves in old age. Are there siblings who are unemployed and likely to